CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Iranian Antisemitism and the International Response

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Since President Rouhani's inauguration in summer 2013, the Islamic Republic of Iran (IRI) has aimed to move away from confrontation and "toward dialogue, constructive interaction, and understanding," as foreign minister Mohammad Zarif put it.[1] However, during the Gaza war of summer 2014, the Iranian leadership showed its old and ugly face. Israel is a "wolf-like and child-killer regime, for which the only solution is its annihilation and liquidation," declared Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei on 23 July 2014 to his followers. "The solution is total armed resistance against this regime. The entire world. . .must help arm the Palestinian nation as much as possible."[2]

The revolutionary leader did not stand alone. Foreign Minister Zarif turned to Hamas leader, Khaled Mashal, to assure him of Iran's full support. Former President Rafsanjani emphasized, "that we have armed the Palestinians," while President Rouhani tried to outbid the revolutionary leader's hate rhetoric: "Today, this festering tumor has opened once again and has turned the land of olives into destruction and blood and littered the land with the body parts of Palestinian children."[3]

Tehran's unconditional and united solidarity with Hamas was noteworthy for several reasons: first, during the conflict, Hamas acted with particular brutality against the Palestinian civilian population, abusing them as human shields.

Second, for the first time, Hamas's rocket attacks found no support in the Arab world, with the exception of Qatar. Third, Iran was the only major nation backing Hamas, although, as a Sunni movement, Hamas supports the fight against Iran's ally Assad in the Syrian civil war.

How did the Western powers respond to Iran's reignited war rhetoric ? At least in public, not at all. Iran's renewed warmongering played no role either at the subsequent talks about the Iranian nuclear program or during the

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